



The writer is the author of *Almost Single*

Society of Perception

Amid sacrifices and compromises, there is a need for urban women to redefine themselves

I am no statistician; after all, if we were to go purely by the demographic proof, I would fall under the convenient category of "variance" or rather deviance, which might be the more appropriate term. However, I am not immune to these amuse-bouche fashioned bits of information. After all, we all exist in the silent, contemplative hope that things are changing. Keeping the best principles of *The Secret* in mind, we whisper them into the universe, hoping that our hopes will manifest into the very things that statistics reveal. The "new Indian Man" drum roll, please, nothing? What's that I hear? My very whisperings echoing back at me, no drum roll?

If there was ever a euphemism for being eligible, for the longest time it was "convent educated", "tall", "fair", "sharp features", "below 30, preferably below 25". Every little girl carrying a little tear sheet of this checklist folded into her pocket, folded up much like the dreams she has to live without one day. Like a match-the-following quiz, every perception linked with displayed behaviour never mind what the heart or the instinct said. Behaviours that are pre-meditated to fit the social requisites of propriety, passed on from generation to generation. After all, our mothers had sacrificed; so had our grandmothers and so had their mothers. This was part of life. In our histories and our present, the circumcision of behaviour was as much a reality as the circumcision of desire that feminists in the western hemisphere decry. We were and still are a society of perception, more so than one of reality, especially when it comes to women. Hence our collective histories, our mythologies were constantly beckoning us, that invisible string of conscience that works us like a pulley system—sometimes up, sometimes down—was tirelessly manipulating our self-esteem. How then could we deviate?

That road hadn't been built yet, or so we thought.

And then somewhere along the way, the language started to change, ever so slightly. In the daily idioms of our conversations between mothers and daughters, sisters and friends there was a change. From sacrifice, the acceptable term became compromise. After all, to get, you must give. But soon enough compromise became the big "C" word in a young woman's world, so we picked another one, "adjust". Adjust, we were told by elders and peers, if you want to live a wholesome and "complete" life. Translation, a life with a man. But for today's urban woman, adjustment really is about setting the reclining posture in her car at the right angle! So have we then maybe got ahead of the language, outrun the idioms—have we then moved ahead of (God help us) men? Or did they merely stop at the curb, while we raced ahead? We may have been too quick to admit into our consciousness only those histories that justify our sprint. We may have equated getting ahead with change; we may have

denied things to ourselves as opposed to having them denied to us. We might possibly still be self-programmed to sacrifice, only this time we choose what we let go of. And most scary of all, we may have let go too easily of that which matters.

This is certainly no critique of our journeys neither is it a celebration of every choice along the way. It is at best a call to reflect, a call to get off this dizzy carousel of experience and opportunity and understand our needs. Not to be entirely dismissive of our histories and neither to be too permissive of expectations; for the truth lies there somewhere, between this ride we are on and our insatiable need to define and redefine ourselves to the exclusion of all else. And most importantly it is to realise that although our progress and failure is all too often assessed in the context of men, it has so very little to do with them. ■

SAURABH SINGH/www.indiatodayimages.com



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